Union ministers, where both sides had reportedly agreed to meet again on May 4 and hold nationwide stakeholder consultations. But Mann was apparently growing impatient. While he had been facing accusations of succumbing to the protesters time and again, many in the government believed that the frequent highway blockades were hurting the state's economy and frustrating the non-agricultural population. In the 2024 general election, a significant chunk of these voters is believed to have shifted away from AAP. Even a fortnight before the March 20 operation, the Mann government had detained prominent farm leaders Balbir Singh Rajewal, Ruldu Singh Mansa and Joginder Singh Ugrahan, thwarting their plans to protest outside the CM's residence in Chandigarh. On March 3, Mann had also walked out of a meeting with the union leaders.

WHO'S THE BOSS?

Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann has cracked down on farmer protesters, striking revenue officials and drug traffickers, asserting control—yet his autonomy is being tested

AAP's central leadership, led by Arvind Kejriwal, is tightening its grip on Punjab, with key aides now overseeing state affairs and speculation about his own political ambitions rising



Around the same time, his government moved against striking revenue officials, who were protesting vigilance actions against some of their colleagues in Ludhiana. After making unannounced visits to Banur, Mohali and Kharar on March 4, Mann suspended 15 tehsildars and naib tehsildars, including Punjab Revenue Officers' Association chief Lachman Singh Randhawa, citing negligence of duty. To ensure continuity of work, the government reassigned their duties to junior officers. Observers say this served both as an administrative clean-up and an assertion of power against bureaucratic resistance.

Simultaneously, the government has intensified its campaign against drug traffickers. On March 17, the state police demolished the house of an absconding drug dealer, Gurcharan Singh, in Ferozepur, citing illegal construction. This was part of a crackdown launched in late February, wherein properties of alleged drug peddlers have been razed in Patiala, Ropar, Amritsar and Ludhiana. With this, Punjab has become the first non-BJP-ruled state to embrace Yogi Adityanath-style "bulldozer justice". Before letting the bulldozers lose, Mann had met the police top brass, giving them three months to curb drug trafficking. The department has prepared a dossier on 78 peddlers whose properties they plan to target next, but legal hurdles remain. Human rights groups have moved the high court, citing a Supreme Court verdict from November 2024 that bars such executive action.

These aggressive moves come as Mann seeks to win over party legislators while tackling growing anti-incumbency against his government. After AAP's underwhelming Lok Sabha performance in Punjab, where it won only three out of 13 seats, the central leadership has already tightened its grip on the state unit. Kejriwal, now unseated as Delhi chief minister, has shifted focus to Punjab, holding meetings and lending his rhetorical energies to the party's crackdown on drugs and corruption. On March 21, he appointed former Delhi ministers Manish Sisodia and Satyendar Jain as AAP's Punjab in-charge and co-incharge, respectively. Both are believed to have better working relationships with Mann than their predecessors, Rajya Sabha MPs Raghav Chadha and Sandeep Pathak.

In the midst of all this, speculation is rife about an impending cabinet reshuffle after two of Mann's ministers, Lal Chand Kataruchak and Harbhajan Singh ETO, were summoned to Delhi and asked to present reports on fund utilisation by their departments. This is similar to developments that took place before massive restructuring late last year, when Mann had to cede the state unit reins to his bête noire Aman Arora.

The increased involvement of AAP's central leadership in Punjab has complicated Mann's political positioning, especially in a state with strong sub-regional sentiments. His opponents have been quick to highlight Kejriwal's growing influence, citing the appointment of loyalists in key state positions, even as the party boss has downplayed speculation about replacing Mann. The recent announcement of Rajya Sabha MP Sanjeev Arora as AAP's candidate for the Ludhiana West assembly seat has only fuelled talk that Kejriwal wants to enter Parliament through Punjab.

Even as Mann appears determined to project a tougher, more autonomous image, his critics dismiss his recent actions as "headline-grabbing". "There have been cops dismissed for their links to drug traffickers and gangsters.... Why haven't bulldozers gone to their homes?" leader of the Opposition Partap Sigh Bajwa questioned in the assembly. Mann's political battle—both within and outside his party—seems far from over. ■